

From A Hacker's Diary

No MP3 Business Please!

I was reading 'Digital Certificates' by Jalal Feghhi, when Sam, a friend of mine and a free software enthusiast, called me on my mobile. He wanted to fix some bugs associated with OGA files. He was trying to experiment with those Ogg files on his Samsung P520 mobile. He wanted to free his musical tracks too!

Ogg can multiplex a number of independent, free, and open source codecs for audio, video, text (say for subtitles) and meta data. I've been told that the word Ogg comes from the name of the character Nanny Ogg appearing in Terry Pratchett's Discworld novels! There is another version too. It says that Ogg comes from "ogging", jargon from the computer game Netrek, which is used to refer to an activity that is done forcefully (without even considering about the future resources).

Ogg is a free, open standard container format (that too a professional-grade media format) and its source is maintained by the Xiph Foundation. The source code (called libvorbis) is available on the download page of the foundation's site at <http://xiph.org/downloads/>. You can also use aoTuV, an upgraded version of the latest release of libvorbis (1.2.0), for obtaining better audio quality, especially at low bit rates. In a standard frame, Theora will offer a video layer, while the Vorbis codec basically acts as the audio layer.

MP3 files are generally restricted by patents. But that is not the case with Ogg Vorbis. It respects one's freedom. I remember when Microsoft was asked to pay some \$1.5 billion for using MP3 without getting a license. Now they too are safe if they come to the free software world for getting resources for their

products! Even larger players in the market like RealPlayer have started using Ogg implementations.

It was way back in 1998, when the development work of Vorbis (<http://www.vorbis.com/>) had started, when Fraunhofer-Gesellschaft announced the decision to charge licensing fees for the MP3 format. Then Christopher "Monty" Montgomery, a multimedia programmer and an open source advocate, pioneered the works and founded Xiph. And finally they succeeded in bringing out the stable version (1.0) in the second half of 2002. Vorbis is now commonly used along with the standard Ogg container, and is therefore called as Ogg Vorbis.

Ogg is, in fact, the general format. We use OGA for audio, OGV for video (including Theora) and OGX for applications. Now using libogg, a BSD-licensed library, every one like Sam can encode and decode their data.

Sam's issue was basically with the driver. But I have seen some even wondering how to access Ogg Vorbis (that encodes audio) and Ogg Theora (that encodes video) files. If they had tried using any free software players (media players), their doubts would have been answered. I recommended VLC Media Player (the player that I like the most) to all those who wrote to me regarding this.

You might think that patent lawsuits concerned with these will never affect you. However, you are partially wrong. You have limited your skills and creativity. He has chained his skills and creativeness. For example, players like Windows Media Player and RealPlayer require people to use non-free software and they are controlled solely by the respective companies. The ultimate result is that he cannot develop



Aasis Vinayak

multimedia software without thinking about the legal complications arising out their deployment.

Recently, one of my friends launched a project to create an interactive modular soft-synth. He says that 'the Psychosynth project (www.psychosynth.com) allows newbies, developers and professionals explore new ways of making music'. The advantage is all that concerning the Freedom—as it does not require the use of proprietary software. This is also directed towards the same goal.

This 'freedom' has led to the use of Ogg's various codecs in various other free and proprietary media players. The list appeared to be interesting to me, as it included both commercial and non-commercial media players, portable media players and even GPS receivers from various companies.

The prime reason for this endorsement, even from those proprietary giants, is that the quality of the files is not lost when Ogg Vorbis is used. Further, it is able to compress audio down to a size smaller than MP3 and is freely re-implementable in the respective software. The only thing that matters to me is to break away from limitations. Absolute freedom is not far away for me.

readersletters@thinkdigit.com

The writer is the developer of Mozhi (www.mozhi.org)—an Indian Language search engine, and the CEO of The Analyst Magazine (www.theanalystmagazine.com) and Free Lecture Notes (www.freelecturenotes.org). His research work / publications in Computer Science and Physics are available at www.aasisvinayak.com.

The views expressed in this article are those of the author, and are not intended to represent the views of Digit.